Macedonian. Some had gone as far as claiming that they are descendants of the ancient Macedonians, a claim which had made the Greeks furious. Now, it is very likely that some of the DNA of ancient Macedonians (ethnically different from but culturally very similar to the Hellenic-Greeks) is in the veins of the contemporary (North) Macedonians, but they share most of it with the Slavs who arrived in these parts almost a thousand years later. And it is here that one should look for the real causes of the bickering: northern parts of Greece are still populated by the remnants of a Slavic (Macedonian) population and their modest claims for a kind of minority status seem to threaten the sense of national unity that Greece has developed since World War I. In addition, this same population stood firmly on the Communist side in the Greek civil war in the late 1940s, which was certainly not helpful during the military regime and in the context of relations with Yugoslavia.

At last both nations came to their senses and found the strength to overcome respective sensitivities, signing the Prespa agreement in 2018. This paved the way to North Macedonia's membership of NATO in 2020. However, the road to the EU was then blocked by another neighbour, Bulgaria, which does not have a problem with the name, but – given their interwoven history and the close proximity of the two languages – questions the very existence of a separate Macedonian identity and language.

At the centre of the dispute between North Macedonia and Bulgaria are the formative years of both nations in the late nineteenth century, when the Ottoman Empire began to collapse and a number of south-eastern European countries formed or restored their autonomy, inspired by humanistic and Enlightenment ideals which had taken so much longer to arrive in the region.[25] Through the two so-called Balkan wars on the eve of World War I, Greece, Serbia, Bulgaria and Romania fully regained their independence, but what are now Macedonians got caught between Bulgaria, Serbia and Greece. After World War I, the new Kingdom of Yugoslavia, in reality an extension of the restored Serbian monarchy, took over most of the Balkan Peninsula, including Macedonians, then essentially treated as Serbs.

In Bulgaria of today, however, there is a strongly-held view that (North) Macedonians are in fact Bulgarians, who by reasons of history and politics ended up in a nation state of their own. In 2022, the Bulgarian parliament finally showed readiness to give up its veto on the start of EU accession